The (De)Evolution of Title IX in the Media: How Title IX has Morphed from a Symbol of Equality for Women's Sport to a Lexicon of Sexualized Violence in U.S. Colleges

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Primary Aims of Paper

The fundamental aim of this paper is to better understand the discourses being produced – and in turn, heard – around Title IX within the United States over the last ten years, with particular attention to the topics of sport and sexual violence in mass media.

Introduction

Unequivocally, the poster child of Title IX since 1972 has been the thousands of girls' who now participate in a variety of sports at various levels of competition.

Image 1a. From a Title IX site, Senator Birch Bayh exercising with Tile IX female runners at Purdue University in 1972.

In 2002, a female student at the University of Georgia sued a male athlete for sexual assault, which snowballed into a succession of hundreds of Title IX lawsuits against U.S. colleges / universities.

Image 1b. Poster of Jameis Winston, former quarterback for Florida State, who was accused of raping a fellow student in a series of scandalous events from 2012 – 2014.

In recent years, the mediated image of Title IX has shifted from being an All-American girl participating in sports to a collegiate woman as a victim of, or a protester against, campus sexual assault.

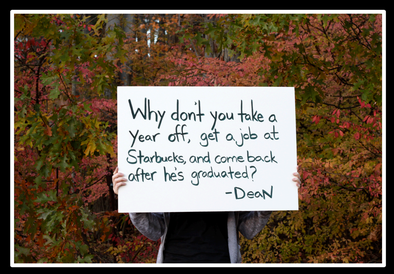

Image 1c. A protestor at Amherst College on the front page of The Nation in a 2014 article on protecting students.

The New York Times · Los Angeles Times · The Washington Post · The Chronicle of Higher Education

Methods

Of the top ten most popular newspapers in the United States the New York Times, the Los Angeles Times, and the Washington Post all met the following requirements. Each:

- has a weekday circulation of over 500,000 copies sold
- offered the appropriate parameters on their website
- produced 150+ articles related to Title IX since 2005
- represented a different regional perspective

To validate data found in the major newspapers, media from The Chronicle of Higher Education was analyzed.

Articles	Year	Null	Relevant	Women Sport	Violence	Sport + Violence
56	2015	0	56	0	1	0
61	2014	0	61	0	1	0
33	2013	1	32	0	0	0
18	2012	1	17	0	0	0
15	2011	1	14	0	0	0
16	2010	1	15	0	0	0
26	2009	0	26	0	1	0
30	2008	1	29	0	0	0
58	2007	0	58	1	0	0
39	2006	1	38	0	0	0
87	2005	0	87	1	0	0
439		6	433	2	3	0

Figure 1. Sample Number of Newspaper Articles Discussing Title IX as Related to Sport and Sexual Harassment in the United States by Year

Articles containing the phrase 'Title IX' in the four media sources between January 1, 2005 and October 1, 2015 were coded for general themes and categorized as either null or into one of three specific typologies:

1. Articles about Title IX and Women in Sport
2. Articles about Title IX and Sexual Violence
3. Articles about Title IX, Sport, and Sexual Violence

Figure 3a. Image of November 2010 *New York Times* article coded as null as it only discussed high school athletes.

Figure 3b. Image of January 2012 *Chronicle of Higher Education* article coded as college and women's sport.

Image 3c. Image of August 2015 *Los Angeles Times* article coded as college and sexual violence.

Image 3d. Image of February 2015 *Washington Post* article coded as sport, college, and sexual violence.

Results

In the last ten years, 21.5% of the articles written about Title IX were about women in sport, 23.8% were about sexual violence, and 7.6% were about both topics.

The number of articles written about Title IX vacillated most greatly from 2012 (24 articles) to 2014 (237 articles).

There was an steep increase in the number of articles written about sexual violence and Title IX on college campuses, culminating in 194 articles written in 2013.

There was a less drastic, though still significant, decline in the number of articles written exclusively about women in sport throughout that time.

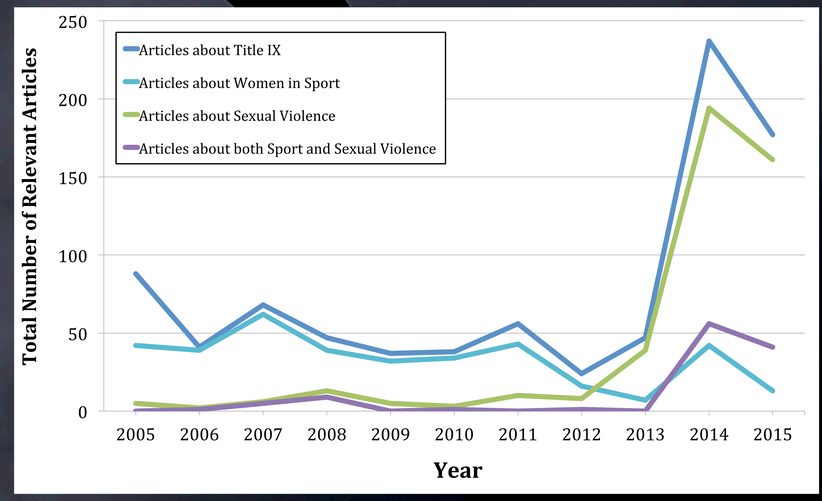

Figure 2. Timeline of Publications written about Title IX in Last Decade

Key Findings

88% of the articles written about sexual violence on campuses and Title IX were written from 2013 to 2015.

The largest number of articles written about Title IX were published between April and September of 2014 as a domino effect of scandalous events being discussed in the media occurred across the nation.

More has been written about Title IX and sexual violence in the last 3 years than was written about women in sport in the last decade.